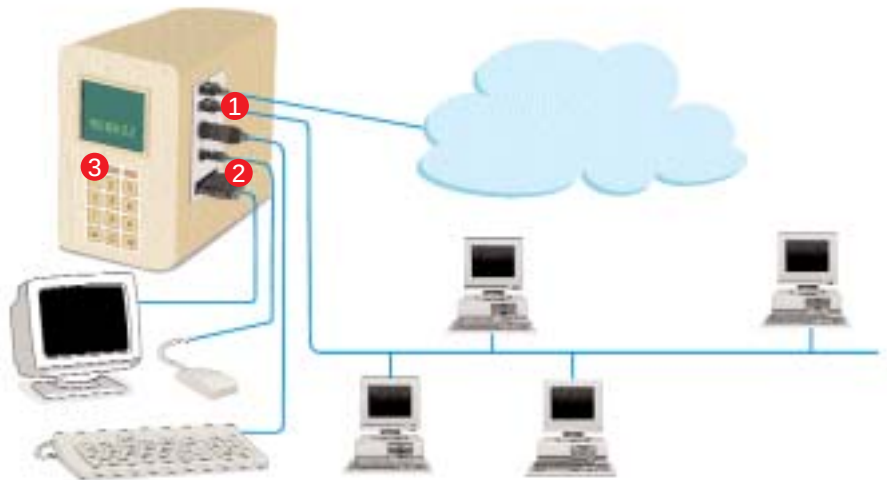




Buying Tips

- ✓ **NETWORK PORTS:** Look for two network connectors in the device. Some devices have a history of providing only one connector. The first port helps you connect to the internal network, and the second to the external network.
- ✓ **OPERATING SYSTEM:** The OS affects the overall performance of the gateway. A stable operating system such as Linux has a dual advantage—stability and licensing costs.
- ✓ **CONFIGURATION OPTIONS:** Generally, the device will offer a console port plus browser based configuration option. But some devices even offer a command line-based option to configure devices. An elite few offer VGA, keyboard and mouse ports so you can convert to a full-fledged PC when the need arises.
- ✓ **KEYPAD AND LCD SCREEN:** Having an LCD screen and a keypad apart from the other connectors helps instant configuration as a standalone device, without the need for browser-based configuring, or connecting to a PC or a network.
- ✓ **PORTS:** Inclusion of parallel, serial, USB, and IDE ports helps you to expand the functionality of the device. For example, a device with an LPT port can act as a print server.
- ✓ **INBUILT MODEM:** An inbuilt modem is necessary for the gateway to function properly over a dial-up Internet connection. If the device has both a network port and a modem, it can act as the primary as well as the backup Internet server. If the primary Internet service is down, it can connect using the modem and provide Internet access.
- ✓ **GSM-READINESS:** Some of the newer devices also support connection through a GSM network. These devices either have a built in modem, or need an external GSM modem. Apart from the device and modem, you will also need a SIM, and a data-capable account from your GSM network provider.
- ✓ **FUNCTIONS:** Generally, these devices appear in three categories. One is simple gateway appliances with basic functionality. Another is content-filtering appliances that can filter out viruses and spam, apart from providing basic functionality. The all-in-one category includes everything—anti-virus, anti-spam, firewall, e-mail server, Web server, etc.



- 1 **Network Connector:** One network connector is used to connect to the internal network while the other connects to the Internet.
- 2 **PC ports:** Connectors to connect the device to the display, the keyboard and the mouse, so that it can be converted to a full fledged PC. Not all such devices have these ports; some just have a console port to connect to the serial port of the PC.
- 3 **LCD panel:** An LCD screen and a small pad to configure the devices provides very limited configuration. Options are either available as a Web-based system or via a console port software.



Facts

- Technology adoption rate amongst Indian SMEs is higher than in their counterparts in countries such as Australia, Japan, China and South Korea.
- Integrated solutions provide hardware and software under one roof; these components are known to be thoroughly tested to work with one another.
- These appliances are actually full fledged computers, either with or without support for displays, keyboards and mice.

The Future

Internet Gateway Appliances provide simple and cost-effective ways to add intelligence and functionality to networks. Today's appliances are two-network-port (LAN/WAN) devices available in specialized, small form factor or 1U or 2U chassis, and support a variety of general purpose OS functions. But the current trend shows a shift from network architecture to more intelligent service-based appliances. Some of these intelligent service-based appliances we can expect to see in the future are: Quality of Service (QoS) appliances that would provide the required level of service to an application in order to maintain an expected quality level, policy-based management appliances that will allow application of rules to define resource access and usage, and network monitoring appliances to analyse and track network activity.

Quick Find	
YOU NEED	A simple gateway appliance
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	An easy-to-use appliance with a simple GUI, which provides all the hardware and software needed, integrated into one device
YOU NEED	A content filtering appliance
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	A device that bundles basic functionality and also provides the option to expand as and when the organisational needs increase
YOU NEED	An all-in-one appliance
Prof Use	
LOOK FOR	A device that bundles anti-virus, anti-spam and firewall functionality, in addition to that of e-mail and Web server. Perhaps a device with necessary connectors to convert it to a full fledged PC